UTTAR PRADESH

Thakur? No, Mathur

There are no signs of two impish hired goons on the horizon. So this is a *Sholay* where Thakur has to do it alone...er, make that Mathur. The hurly-burly of campaigning brought a nasty little accident for 66-year-old **Pradeep Mathur,** Congress candidate from Mathura and a four-time MLA. His left hand bore the brunt of it—X-rays showed multiple fractures. But



Mathur is loath to pull out. Instead, he has postponed his operation to continue campaigning, adapting the famous movie dialogue for a new slogan: "*Ek haath hi kaafi hai BJP ko haraane ke liye*". Mathura, which votes on February 10, is among those few constituencies where the Congress is in a direct one-on-one fight with the BJP. Unlike the Thakur of *Sholay*, Mathur of Mathura is also banking on sympathy. He may need it. Read the last item on the opposite page to know why. ■



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

THE GRAND OLD MEN

94 NOT OUT... AND NON-STRIKER, 83

A lot of talk in politics is, by definition, age-ist. Buzzphrases like 'the Young Turks' or 'youth dividend' seem to shine like dew when juxtaposed against 'the old guard' or 'margdarshak mandal'. But there are two veterans in the game who refuse to show any signs of retiring. One is an octogenarian who has opted out of the contest rather reluctantly. The other, 11 years older, is actually contesting. It was circa 1947, a full three quarters of a century ago, that Parkash Singh became the sarpanch of his village, Badal. As a mere 20-year-